are the most southerly Ashokan edicts yet discovered. The Hiregudda ridge north of Bellary, site of the Neolithic stone factory and petroglyphs, is also shown, along with the main river systems in the area.

One of the eleven known Ashokan major rock edict sites is at Dhauligiri, or ‘the hill of Dhauli’, little more than a modest rise overlooking an equally modest river, the Daya, just above the point where that river joins the much larger Kuakhai to flow north past the town of Bhubaneshwar in Odisha and then eastwards into the Bay of Bengal. The Sanskrit word *daya* means ‘compassion’. Precisely when this little river was first given that name is not known but it must have been soon after the terrible battle of Kalinga, which was fought here in or about the year 263 BCE.

Ashoka’s words have been cut into the smoothed side of a large rock that is topped by the figure of a standing tusked elephant, of which only the head and front legs have been carved (see illustration). That the battlefield massacre took place here at Dhauli seems indisputable. The late conservationist and founder of the Elephant Family charity Mark Shand told me how in the course of his journey with the elephant Tara that became the subject of his best-seller *Travels with my Elephant* he rode Tara into this area completely unaware of its past history. As they approached Dhauli the elephant refused to go forward; nothing that Mark or the mahout did could persuade her to cross the open ground in front of them. Only then did Mark learn that they had come to the Kalinga battlefield, on which hundreds of war elephants are said to have died. Mark ascribed Tara’s behaviour to ancestral memory, passed on from one elephant to another over two thousand years and more. ‘Elephants never forget,’ he reminded me.